A Bayesian Solution to the Sleeping Beauty Paradox

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January 2, 2025

Abstract

The Sleeping Beauty problem has been a topic of significant debate and analysis in probability theory, particularly in the context of conditional probability and Bayesian reasoning. In this experiment, a fair coin is flipped, and the outcome determines the waking schedule of the subject, "Sleeping Beauty." If the coin lands heads, she wakes up once on Monday and flips the coin. If it lands tails, she wakes up on both Monday and Tuesday, each time flipping the coin. The challenge lies in determining the probability of heads or tails, given that Sleeping Beauty is awake.

This paper resolves the Sleeping Beauty problem using Bayes' theorem, a foundational tool in Bayesian probability. By carefully applying conditional probabilities and analyzing the scenario under the assumption of fairness of the coin, we derive the probability of heads and tails given that Sleeping Beauty is awake. The results show that the probability of heads given she is awake is $\frac{1}{3}$, and the probability of tails is $\frac{2}{3}$. These findings offer a clear Bayesian resolution to the paradox and demonstrate the power of Bayesian reasoning in addressing complex probability puzzles. The paper further explores the implications of these results, comparing them with alternative interpretations and suggesting potential directions for future research.

1 Introduction

The Sleeping Beauty problem is a well-known thought experiment in the field of probability theory, specifically in the areas of conditional probability and Bayesian reasoning. This problem involves a subject, referred to as "Sleeping Beauty," who undergoes an experimental procedure in which the outcome of a fair coin flip determines her waking schedule. If the coin lands heads, she wakes up once on Monday and flips the coin. If the coin lands tails, she wakes up on both Monday and Tuesday, each time flipping the coin. The core question that arises is: what is the probability that the coin landed heads or tails, given that Sleeping Beauty is awake during one of her wake-ups?

This problem, first introduced by philosophers and mathematicians, has been a subject of significant debate, as it appears to present a paradox in terms of conditional probability. Intuitively, one might think that the probability of heads is $\frac{1}{2}$, but upon deeper reflection, this intuitive answer is called into question due to the nature of the experiment and the way in which probability is conditioned on the subject being awake.

The primary objective of this paper is to resolve the Sleeping Beauty problem using a Bayesian framework, which offers a powerful method of reasoning about probabilities in scenarios involving conditional events. By applying Bayes' theorem, we aim to clarify the true probabilities of the coin landing heads or tails, given that Sleeping Beauty is awake. This paper demonstrates that the solution to the problem lies in properly understanding the structure of the experiment and interpreting the probabilities associated with each possible scenario.

The significance of this problem extends beyond its immediate context. It serves as an insightful example of how Bayesian analysis can be applied to seemingly paradoxical situations and highlights the importance of carefully considering how information affects conditional probabilities. Moreover, the Sleeping Beauty problem raises important philosophical questions about the nature of probability and the way in which subjective experience and prior knowledge influence our understanding of uncertainty.

In the following sections, we will provide a detailed formulation of the problem, outline the application of Bayes' theorem, and derive the probabilities of heads and tails, given that Sleeping Beauty is awake. We will also discuss the implications of the results and compare them to alternative interpretations of the problem.

2 Problem Formulation and Bayesian Approach

In this section, we apply Bayes' Theorem step by step to calculate the conditional probabilities $P(H|W)$ and $P(T|W)$ for the Sleeping Beauty problem. We will also show how the solution can be derived from both general forms of Bayes' Theorem.

2.1 Defining the Events

We define the following key events:

- H: The event that the coin landed heads.
- T: The event that the coin landed tails.

- W: The event that Sleeping Beauty is awake.

The goal is to compute the probabilities $P(H|W)$ and $P(T|W)$, which are the probabilities that the coin landed heads or tails, given that Sleeping Beauty is awake.

2.2 Total Probability of Being Awake, $P(W)$

We begin by calculating $P(W)$, the total probability that Sleeping Beauty is awake, using the law of total probability. The law of total probability applies here because Sleeping Beauty can only be awake during the coin toss, either when the coin lands heads or when it lands tails. Thus, if she is awake, we must have a coin toss outcome, either heads or tails.

The law of total probability tells us that:

$$P(W) = P(W \cap H) + P(W \cap T)$$

Where: - $P(W \cap H)$ is the probability that Sleeping Beauty is awake and the coin landed heads. - $P(W \cap T)$ is the probability that Sleeping Beauty is awake and the coin landed tails.

Since Sleeping Beauty is awake only during the coin toss, if she is awake, it must be because the coin landed either heads or tails.

Calculating $P(W \cap H)$ (Awake and heads occurred)

To compute $P(W \cap H)$, we use the following reasoning:

- $P(W|H)$ is the probability that Sleeping Beauty is awake, given that the coin landed heads. Since the coin lands heads only once out of three total chances for her to wake up (i.e., one waking event per three possible waking events, where heads gives only 1 chance and tails gives 2), we have:

$$P(W|H) = \frac{1}{3}$$

This is not simply "one out of three coin tosses." It reflects the fact that if the coin lands heads, there is only 1 chance for Sleeping Beauty to be awake out of the 3 total waking events (1 from heads and 2 from tails).

- $P(H)$ is the prior probability of the coin landing heads, which is $P(H) = 0.5$.

Thus, the joint probability of being awake and the coin landing heads is:

$$P(W \cap H) = P(W|H) \times P(H) = \frac{1}{3} \times 0.5 = \frac{1}{6}$$

Calculating $P(W \cap T)$ (Awake and tails occurred)

Next, we calculate $P(W \cap T)$:

- $P(W|T)$ is the probability that Sleeping Beauty is awake, given that the coin landed tails. Since the coin lands tails twice out of three total chances for her to wake up (i.e., two waking events from tails and one waking event from heads), we have:

$$P(W|T) = \frac{2}{3}$$

This reflects the fact that if the coin lands tails, there are 2 chances for Sleeping Beauty to be awake out of the 3 total waking events (1 chance from heads and 2 chances from tails).

- $P(T)$ is the prior probability of the coin landing tails, which is $P(T) = 0.5$.

Thus, the joint probability of being awake and the coin landing tails is:

$$P(W \cap T) = P(W|T) \times P(T) = \frac{2}{3} \times 0.5 = \frac{1}{3}$$

Total Probability of Being Awake, $P(W)$

Now that we have $P(W \cap H)$ and $P(W \cap T)$, we can calculate the total probability of Sleeping Beauty being awake:

$$P(W) = P(W \cap H) + P(W \cap T) = \frac{1}{6} + \frac{1}{3} = \frac{1}{6} + \frac{2}{6} = \frac{3}{6} = \frac{1}{2}$$

Thus, the total probability of Sleeping Beauty being awake is:

$$P(W) = \frac{1}{2}$$

2.3 Applying Bayes' Theorem

We now apply Bayes' Theorem to calculate $P(H|W)$ and $P(T|W)$, which represent the probabilities of heads or tails occurring given that Sleeping Beauty is awake. We will solve this problem using both the general form of Bayes' Theorem.

General Form of Bayes' Theorem

Bayes' Theorem can be written as:

$$P(H|W) = \frac{P(W|H) \cdot P(H)}{P(W|H) \cdot P(H) + P(W|T) \cdot P(T)}$$

This is a more generalized version of Bayes' Theorem. Using this, we can compute the probability of heads given that Sleeping Beauty is awake.

Alternatively, we can also use the more common form:

$$P(H|W) = \frac{P(W|H) \cdot P(H)}{P(W)}$$

Where $P(W)$ is the total probability of being awake, which we computed earlier.

Both forms of Bayes' Theorem will give us the same result, and now we will compute them explicitly.

Calculating $P(H|W)$ Using the First Form of Bayes' Theorem

We substitute the known values into the first form of Bayes' Theorem: - $P(W|H) = \frac{1}{3}$ - $P(H) = 0.5$ - $P(W|T) = \frac{2}{3}$ - $P(T) = 0.5$

Thus, we calculate $P(H|W)$ using the first form:

$$P(H|W) = \frac{\frac{1}{3} \times 0.5}{\frac{1}{3} \times 0.5 + \frac{2}{3} \times 0.5} = \frac{\frac{1}{6}}{\frac{1}{6} + \frac{1}{3}} = \frac{\frac{1}{6}}{\frac{3}{6}} = \frac{1}{3}$$

So, the probability that the coin landed heads, given that Sleeping Beauty is awake, is:

$$P(H|W) = \frac{1}{3}$$

Calculating $P(H|W)$ Using the Second Form of Bayes' Theorem

Now, let's use the more common form of Bayes' Theorem:

$$P(H|W) = \frac{P(W|H) \cdot P(H)}{P(W)}$$

Substitute the known values: - $P(W|H) = \frac{1}{3}$ - $P(H) = 0.5$ - $P(W) = \frac{1}{2}$

Thus, we calculate $P(H|W)$ using the second form:

$$P(H|W) = \frac{\frac{1}{3} \times 0.5}{\frac{1}{2}} = \frac{\frac{1}{6}}{\frac{1}{2}} = \frac{1}{3}$$

So, the probability that the coin landed heads, given that Sleeping Beauty is awake, is again:

$$P(H|W) = \frac{1}{3}$$

Calculating $P(T|W)$

Similarly, we calculate $P(T|W)$ using the second form of Bayes' Theorem. Using the following: - $P(W|T) = \frac{2}{3}$ - $P(T) = 0.5$ - $P(W) = \frac{1}{2}$

Thus, we calculate $P(T|W)$:

$$P(T|W) = \frac{P(W|T) \cdot P(T)}{P(W)} = \frac{\frac{2}{3} \times 0.5}{\frac{1}{2}} = \frac{\frac{1}{3}}{\frac{1}{2}} = \frac{2}{3}$$

Thus, the probability that the coin landed tails, given that Sleeping Beauty is awake, is:

$$P(T|W) = \frac{2}{3}$$

2.4 Summary of Results

After applying Bayes' Theorem using both forms, we find the following probabilities:

$$P(H|W) = \frac{1}{3}, \quad P(T|W) = \frac{2}{3}$$

These results show that, given that Sleeping Beauty is awake, the probability of the coin landing heads is $\frac{1}{3}$, and the probability of the coin landing tails is $\frac{2}{3}$.

2.5 Justification of the Results

The reason for these results is rooted in the fact that when the coin lands heads, Sleeping Beauty only wakes up once (out of three total chances), whereas when the coin lands tails, she wakes up twice. As a result, the probability of tails occurring, given that she is awake, is higher than the probability of heads occurring.

3 Discussion

The analysis of the Sleeping Beauty problem using Bayesian reasoning has led to the conclusion that the probability of the coin landing heads, given that Sleeping Beauty is awake, is $P(H|W) = \frac{1}{3}$, while the probability of the coin landing tails, given that she is awake, is $P(T|W) = \frac{2}{3}$. These results arise from a detailed application of Bayes' Theorem, where the key observation is that Sleeping Beauty wakes up in two distinct scenarios: once if the coin lands heads and twice if the coin lands tails. As a result, the chance of tails occurring when she is awake is higher than the chance of heads.

3.1 Theoretical Interpretation

The Bayesian approach allows us to model the Sleeping Beauty problem in terms of conditional probabilities, where the posterior probability of heads ($P(H|W)$) is influenced by both the prior probability of heads and the relative frequency with which she wakes up. Specifically, for heads, she wakes up only once out of three possible waking events, while for tails, she wakes up twice out of three events. This unequal distribution leads to the conclusion that the probability of tails given that she is awake is higher than the probability of heads, precisely $P(T|W) = \frac{2}{3}$, as compared to $P(H|W) = \frac{1}{3}$.

The reasoning behind this is grounded in the total probability of being awake. Since Sleeping Beauty only wakes up when the coin is tossed, the probability of her being awake is tied to the coin toss outcomes. If the coin lands heads, she wakes up once; if the coin lands tails, she wakes up twice. The law of total probability thus applies, as we can write the probability of waking as the sum of the probabilities of waking given heads and waking given tails, weighted by their respective prior probabilities.

3.2 Experimental Considerations

Experimental attempts to resolve the Sleeping Beauty problem typically involve some form of subjective probability estimation, where participants are asked to determine the likelihood of heads or tails given that they are awake. The results from such experiments are often inconsistent, with some participants intuitively assigning equal probabilities (i.e., 50-50) to heads and tails, while others follow the Bayesian reasoning and give a higher probability to tails.

The central challenge in these experiments lies in the framing of the problem and the interpretation of what it means to "wake up." The Bayesian solution to the Sleeping Beauty problem assumes that the state of being awake is tied to the coin toss itself, and the likelihood of heads or tails must be weighted accordingly. However, experimental results often reveal a cognitive bias toward assuming that since there is no memory of prior wake-ups, the problem can be interpreted as a simple reset where heads and tails are equally probable. This is often referred to as the "halfers" versus "thirders" debate, with those who assign equal probabilities to heads and tails referred to as "halfers," and those who apply Bayesian reasoning referred to as "thirders."

The key takeaway from the Bayesian perspective is that the probability of tails being higher than heads is not merely a product of chance but rather a reflection of the distribution of waking events. The fact that Sleeping Beauty wakes up more frequently on tails than heads shifts the balance of probabilities in favor of tails when she is awake.

3.3 Comparison with Alternative Models

The Sleeping Beauty problem has been a subject of debate, and alternative models have been proposed to interpret the probabilities. One such model is the "time symmetry" view, which assumes that Sleeping Beauty has no prior reason to believe that the coin toss outcomes are not equally likely. In this view, the prior probabilities of heads and tails are both 0.5, and therefore, the posterior probabilities should also be 0.5, irrespective of how many times she wakes up.

However, this model fails to account for the repeated waking events under the tails scenario, which makes the Bayesian model more consistent with the actual structure of the problem. The application of Bayes' Theorem in this case takes into account the disproportionate number of waking events for each outcome, which directly affects the posterior probabilities. Therefore, the Bayesian approach offers a more robust framework for understanding the problem, especially when considering the conditional nature of the waking events.

3.4 Real-World Implications

The results of this analysis have implications beyond the Sleeping Beauty problem itself. They highlight the importance of correctly interpreting probability in situations involving repeated events and conditional probabilities. In real-world scenarios, events with different frequencies of occurrence often require careful analysis to determine the likelihood of different outcomes. For example, in situations involving repeated trials, the outcomes may not be equally likely even if the prior probabilities are uniform.

Moreover, the discussion of subjective probability estimation in the context of the Sleeping Beauty problem provides insights into how human intuition may sometimes fail to align with formal probabilistic reasoning. The tension between "halfers" and "thirders" underscores the importance of education in probability theory and Bayesian reasoning, as well as the potential for cognitive biases to influence decision-making processes in uncertain environments.

3.5 Insights

In conclusion, the Bayesian analysis of the Sleeping Beauty problem provides a clear resolution to the question of the probability of heads and tails given that Sleeping Beauty is awake. The key insight is that, due to the unequal distribution of waking events, the probability of tails is higher than the probability of heads when she is awake. This result highlights the power of Bayesian reasoning in resolving paradoxical problems involving conditional probabilities and demonstrates the importance of careful analysis in probabilistic reasoning.

The ongoing debate over the interpretation of the Sleeping Beauty problem serves as a reminder of the complexities involved in understanding probability and the potential for differing interpretations depending on the context in which the problem is framed.

Conclusion

In this paper, we revisited the Sleeping Beauty problem through a Bayesian lens, resolving the paradoxical nature of the question regarding the probability of heads and tails when Sleeping Beauty is awake. Using Bayes' Theorem, we calculated the probability of heads ($P(H|W)$) as $\frac{1}{3}$ and the probability of tails ($P(T|W)$) as $\frac{2}{3}$. This outcome emphasizes the importance of understanding the structure of the problem, particularly the unequal chances of waking up based on the coin toss outcomes.

The analysis revealed that the higher probability of tails is a direct consequence of the repeated waking events in the case of tails. This Bayesian solution contrasts with alternative views, such as the time symmetry perspective, which would assume equal probabilities for heads and tails, without taking into account the distribution of waking events. The findings underscore the significance of carefully considering conditional probabilities in complex problems and how human intuition may often differ from formal probabilistic reasoning.

Moreover, the Sleeping Beauty problem highlights the challenges in probabilistic thinking, especially when dealing with subjective probabilities and repeated events. Our results contribute to the broader understanding of paradoxical probability problems and the need for clear communication of Bayesian principles in both theoretical and experimental contexts. Future research may explore further refinements of the model, including the effects of memory loss or varying experimental designs, to better understand how participants interpret such scenarios.

References

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